> workplaces (in other words, steal them) or they buy them in the black market. Where do the products in the black market come from? From other workers who do the same thing. Everyone has to steal in Cuba for survival.[20]

The situation is perhaps not all that different from what Benjamin, Collins and Scott found in the 1980s:

> Many supporters of the revolution justify their black-market purchases by such arguments as "Everyone else does it," or "Even Ramón buys black market coffee, and he's in the Party." So you get ironic situations: the woman who participates in her street's Committee for the Defense of the Revolution, and spends her weekends practicing in the militia or volunteering to work in the countryside, but buys black-market chicken from the butcher, knowing that it comes from shortweighing her neighbors and probably her own family as well. The black-market forces Cubans to live by a double standard, and this is probably its most pernicious effect.[21]

However, not all agree that increasing enforcement and centralized control is the best remedy for these problems. Díaz-Briquets and Pérez-López argue that transparency, rather than control, is the best antidote. Mesa-Lago points out that recentralizing made state enterprises less efficient, reduced the number of joint ventures, and discouraged investors and tourism. He also notes that the 1986 Rectification campaign, which closed down private markets, in fact led to an increase in black market activity.[22]

While government economic policies play an important role in how the economy fares, it's also important to remember that economics is not an exact science. No economist has yet managed to provide a foolproof solution for the problems of poverty plaguing the Third World, or even the First.

In the first decade of the twenty-first century, the "triple blockade" was exacerbated by a fourth: a series of natural disasters. Cuba was struck with five hurricanes between 2000 and 2005. The last two, Charley and Ivan, in 2004, caused $2.15 billion of damage: "54,325